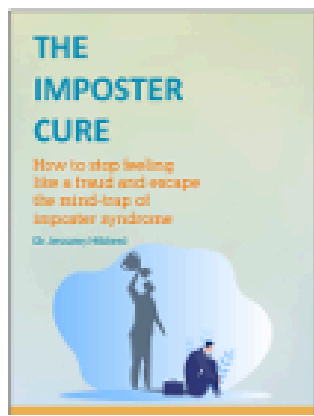




THE IMPOSTER CURE

How To Stop Feeling Like A Fraud And Escape
The Mind-trap Of The Imposter Syndrome

DR. JESSAMY HIBBERD



Introduction



The imposter syndrome occurs when people believe that they're not worthy of success and lack the skills, competence or intelligence expected of them. As a result, they feel undeserving of their achievements and are constantly afraid of being exposed as a fraud.



In this book, clinical psychologist Dr Jessamy Hibberd provides a step-by-step guide to help you understand and overcome the imposter syndrome, rebuild your confidence, health and well-being.

- There are 3 main steps involved:
 - (i) Consciously choose to change;
 - (ii) Understand the theory behind the imposter syndrome; and
 - (iii) Test out all the strategies to find out which ones work for you.
- In this summary, we've consolidated the insights into 2 parts.



Part 1: Understanding the Imposter Syndrome



What's Imposter Syndrome?



Imposter syndrome comes from the underlying fear that you're not good enough. It can affect anyone from students to professors, executives and entrepreneurs.

- About 70% of people have experienced the imposter syndrome at some point, though it affects different people in

KEY QUOTES

"You are enough, right now, exactly as you are."

"You need to want to change, to really listen to the new evidence and you have to test it out."

"The more you know about imposter syndrome the better your chance of beating it."

different degrees. Some occasionally feel worried about their inadequacies, while others are constantly plagued by self-doubt, fear of failure, or fear of being “found out”.

- It usually begins with a task or challenge where the perceived expectations exceed your perceived abilities. Someone with confidence may simply take action to bridge the perceived gap. However, someone who lacks self-belief may start to dwell on their inadequacies and how they might fail. They end up acting in ways that lead to their own failure, which further reinforces their poor self-esteem.
- This is worsened in times of change or difficulty, e.g. when you have a new job, bigger responsibilities, or feel out of place (e.g. a female in a male-dominated sector).



Not everyone defines competence the same way. According to Dr Valerie Young, there are 5 types of imposters. They differ in the yardsticks they use to measure competence.

The 5 Imposter Types



Perfectionist



Expert



Natural Genius



Soloist



Superhuman

- The Perfectionists set impossibly-high standards and seek to achieve them 100% of the time. They beat themselves up even if they're just 1% off the mark. They also dictate how exactly they should achieve the goal and feel dissatisfied if things don't go exactly according to plan.
- The Experts are the knowledge version of the Perfectionist. They expect themselves to know everything, and feel like a failure if there's just a tiny gap in knowledge.
- The Natural Geniuses also set impossibly high standards, but they measure competence based on whether they reach the target on their first attempt. They believe that someone who's naturally talented should be able to do things quickly and effortlessly. They equate struggles with incompetence, and don't cope well with setbacks.
- The Soloists define competence as the ability to do things on their own without assistance. They take pride in the

KEY QUOTES

"Imposter syndrome normally occurs when there is a tension between two views—yours and what you believe others expect of you."

"When perfection is the aim, everything is always going to fall short, and success is seldom satisfying."

ability to do things independently, and see any form of help (e.g. coaching, advice, assistance) to mean they've failed.

- The Superhumans evaluate competence by the number of roles they can juggle and excel in. They expect themselves to perform perfectly in multiple roles (e.g. parent, friend, manager) and tend to overextend themselves.



Which of the 5 imposter types are you likely to be? How does it affect the way you do things, and what negative impact could it have on your life?



The Imposter Mind-Trap



The imposter syndrome involves a set of beliefs, feelings & behaviors that reinforce one another in a vicious cycle.

- Imposters believe that they are not good enough, and see their discomfort and anxiety as evidence of their incompetence.
- To prevent others from discovering that they're frauds, they resort to overwork or avoidance. Unfortunately, such coping strategies only lead to worse performance and/or burnout.
 - (i) Overwork: Hard work is good, but not if you overdo it to expend more energy than needed and sacrifice other priorities, e.g. health and relationships.
 - (ii) Avoidance: You won't realize what you can do if you don't speak up, put yourself forward, take risks, or seek help. Or, you may procrastinate until it's too late to do a good job.
- Even when they succeed, imposters ignore positive feedback or praises, dismiss their achievements and magnify their mistakes, thus reinforcing their negative self-beliefs.



KEY QUOTES

"If you are a Soloist...asking for help is a sign of weakness and you fear it might reveal your incompetence."



The Beliefs Behind Imposter Syndrome



Much of our beliefs are formed during childhood, through a mix of *nature* (personality) and *nurture* (family environment and upbringing).

- Your personality includes your level of extraversion, openness, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and neuroticism. It affects how you interact with the world around you. For example, some babies are more prone to anxiety and cry often. So, their parents may avoid exposing them to new places/people, and strangers tend to stay away from them. Other babies are naturally calmer, so their parents may bring them to new places, and strangers are more likely to approach them. The babies' personalities affect their experiences, which then influence their views of the world.
- The people close to us (e.g. parents, teachers, friends, siblings) also shape our self-concept and how we think we should behave.
 - (i) Children who receive mixed messages about success or are regularly shamed/rejected by their parents are more likely to develop low self-esteem and become more susceptible to the imposter syndrome.
 - (ii) Family members often compare children or use labels like "the trouble-maker" or "the smart one". Both positive and negative labels can be damaging, since children may conclude that they're stupid, or feel pressured to win all the time because they're smart.
 - (iii) Your definition of success and failure is also influenced by how your parents respond to their own successes/failures as well as how they respond to your successes/failures.



Our beliefs and views evolve as we mature, but our childhood imprints remain. Reflect on where your beliefs may have come from:

- What messages did you receive about your ability, intelligence, or importance? Which role models and events impacted you the most (and how)? How did those closest to you respond to your successes and challenges?

KEY QUOTES

"Children tune in to the subtle and not-so-subtle messages they are given, which influence how they think about themselves and the world around them."

"Looking back at your history is not about blaming anyone, it's about understanding yourself better."

- Are those beliefs still valid (correct and updated)?



Our beliefs help us to filter, classify and assimilate information, thus providing a framework to make sense of the world. However, this also leads to a confirmation bias:

- Beliefs/biases are hard to change because we seek out information that support our beliefs and ignore those that don't.
 - (i) We pay more attention to ideas that fit with our beliefs; and
 - (ii) We may distort new information to fit what we "know."
- We also tend to feel strongly about our beliefs. The stronger the emotions associated with a belief, the harder it is to change it.



The imposter syndrome tends to be self-fulfilling:

- If you believe you're an imposter, you'll focus on your shortfalls/inadequacies and dismiss your achievements. Your fear and anxiety impair clear thinking and increase the chances of errors, which further reinforce your sense of inadequacy in a vicious cycle. In the long run, it could even lead to depression and anxiety disorders.
- For example, a successful businessman felt like such a fraud that he was constantly worried he'd fail his loved ones and get "found out". He even feared that someone may show up at his home to tell him the house wasn't his! He became so anxious that he started to flounder at work, drink excessively, and distance himself from those who cared about him.



Part 2: Freeing Yourself From the Imposter Syndrome



The key to change is to realize that you're not an imposter. You're merely *worried* that you're an imposter, which leads to ineffective copings strategies that sabotage your results and well-being.

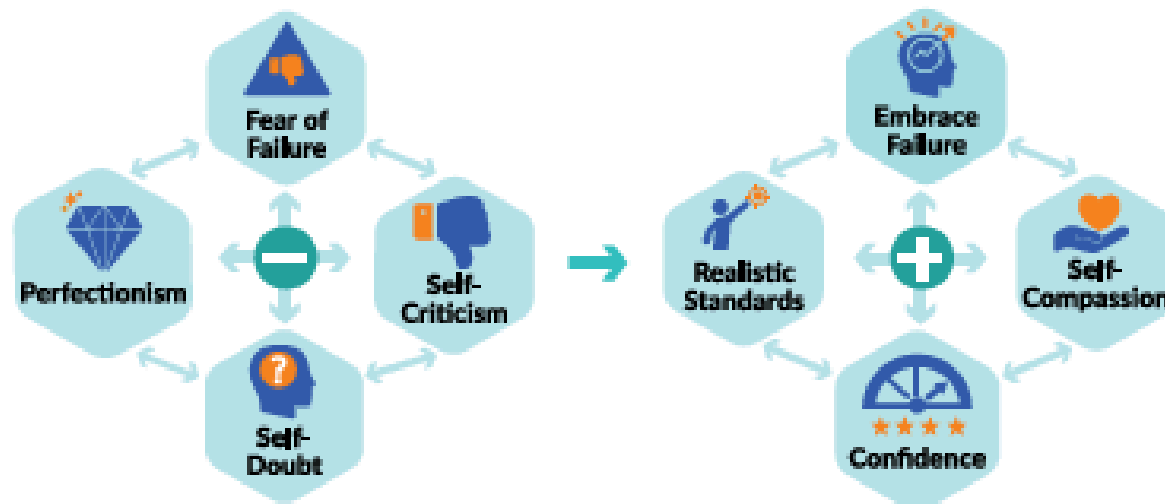
- In this section, we'll address each of the underlying elements—including secrecy, fear of failure, self-criticism, self-doubt,

KEY QUOTES

"Fear can drive us to do things without really thinking them through."

"Just because you worry you are an imposter, it doesn't mean you are one. Your feelings are not facts."

perfectionism, discounting positives and magnifying negatives—and explain how you can break the vicious cycle, adopt helpful strategies and build your confidence.



Replacing Old Beliefs

✗✔ Before you can change your beliefs, you must want to change.
 👉 Realize that you can strive for excellence and be humble without constantly putting yourself down.

👉 Your beliefs are like a well-trodden path. Each supporting thought or action reinforces it until you automatically head down the path whenever you experience a trigger. To change a belief, you must build a new path gradually until it becomes the new default.

- Look for evidence to gradually chip away at old, unhelpful beliefs and see yourself in new light. Practice the strategies below to accelerate the process, like using a lawnmower to clear the new path. The process will get progressively easier with practice.

👉 Externalize the imposter voice, or the voice in your head saying “You’re a fraud” or “Wait till they notice your screw-ups”. Imagine the voice to be that of a bully or someone you won’t take seriously.

🧠 Realize that thoughts and feelings are not facts.

- Emotions help us to understand our inner world and give meaning to life, e.g. love helps us to feel close to others, and fear alerts us to potential danger. However, being afraid doesn’t mean you’re in real danger, and feeling insecure doesn’t mean you’re inadequate. So, don’t judge your abilities using emotions alone.

KEY QUOTES

“Overwork, avoidance, self-criticism and self-doubt are a toxic combination, leading to feelings of shame and inadequacy.”

“Changing your belief about yourself means finding a new path.”

“You need to listen to your feelings, but do not treat them as more important than all other information.”

KEY QUOTES

- Question if there's real evidence to support (or even contradict) the negative voice. How would you react if you heard your friend saying the same things?



Speak with others to realize you're not alone. Many others also feel insecure even if they *appear* confident. Share your experiences and mistakes to help one another to move forward.



There will always be things in life beyond your control. Instead of trying to control everything, learn to embrace uncertainty and see life as an adventure. When you veer off-course, treat it as a chance for exploration. Learn to find solutions to unexpected problems, so you can overcome any challenge and even create better outcomes from setbacks.



Shift from Fear of Failure → Embracing Failure



Imposters tend to be fearful and unforgiving of their failures. They amplify mistakes and see them as a confirmation that they're frauds. This leads to self-doubt and ineffective coping strategies which paradoxically increase their chances of failure.



In reality, everyone makes mistakes and no one knows everything. Accept failures and mistakes as a part of life, growth and success. Instead of avoiding mistakes, use them to learn and build resilience.

- See yourself as a work-in-progress. Give yourself the permission to fail, but learn from every mistake to become better and stronger.
- Don't amplify your anxiety by generalizing, magnifying or personalizing mistakes. Specifically:
 - (i) Don't assume you failed because you're stupid or inadequate. Think "I didn't succeed this time", not "I'll never get it right".
 - (ii) Don't project your own fears to assume that's what others think about you.
 - (iii) Realize that 1 mistake doesn't mean the end of the world.
 - (iv) Don't focus on the 5% that went wrong and ignore the 95% that went well.

"No matter how hard you try, there's no route through life that is pain-free."

"It's a paradox—our successes are achieved through trying, yet trying often ends in failure."

"Overcoming imposter syndrome doesn't mean you'll stop making mistakes; it means accepting that they're part of life and that you need to learn how to use them to your advantage."

"The path to success is not linear and without failure we can't progress."

(v) Don't blame yourself for every bad thing that happens, or for not having foreseen how things would go.

- After every major task or project, reflect on what happened, what you felt, did and learned.
- Criticism ≠ failure. Don't treat negative feedback as a sign of personal failure; keep the useful feedback and drop the rest.
- There're always multiple solutions to a problem. Don't get fixated on 1 "right" choice or approach.



Shift from Self-Criticism → Self-Compassion



You do not need self-criticism to prevent complacency. Chronic self-criticism demoralizes and demotivates you to worsen your results. It's like having a coach who constantly yells at you, reminds you of your failures and tells you that you're useless.



The antidote to self-criticism is self-compassion, i.e. treating yourself kindly and non-judgmentally. It's like having a coach who highlights your strengths, celebrates how you've improved, and points out how you can do even better.

- Self-compassion makes it easier to accept yourself, bounce back from setbacks, and take constructive action. According to Kristin Neff, there are 3 parts to self-compassion:
 - (i) Recognize that you're struggling or stressed without judging or overreacting;
 - (ii) Be understanding and supportive to yourself when you're having a hard time; and
 - (iii) Remember that everyone struggles and makes mistakes.
- To become more compassionate to yourself:
 - (i) Notice your self-criticisms and dial them down, or externalize the voice so you can challenge the statements.
 - (ii) Use an empathetic voice. Think of someone compassionate and imagine how they speak. Then, use that voice to tell the critical voice, "That was hard, but I did my best and I'll improve with practice."

KEY QUOTES

"Self-criticism preys on what's most important to you and makes everything seem worse than it is."

"Think of compassion as the mortar that holds everything together, so you can confidently rebuild the bricks of who you are and how you operate."

"Compassion [is] an essential ingredient for life. Compassion will teach you to support and motivate yourself with kindness rather than criticism."

- (iii) Be kind to yourself, e.g. have a cup of your favorite tea or listen to some calming music.



Shift from Perfectionism → Realistic Standards



Imposters constantly feel like they don't know enough or aren't good/smart enough. By aiming for perfection and unachievable goals, they set themselves up to fail.

- Perfectionists think they'll only be happy when they reach perfection. They feel dissatisfied no matter how good their results are, and feel ashamed each time they miss the mark or allow themselves to relax. They keep pushing harder until they burn out or collapse, or use the pursuit of perfectionism to hide their insecurities.
- Research shows that perfectionists are more likely to suffer from anxiety, depression, chronic fatigue, insomnia, and a range of stress-related disorders.



Go for healthy conscientiousness, not unhealthy perfectionism. You can still strive for excellence without (i) using it to define your self-worth, (ii) sacrificing all other priorities, or (iii) beating yourself up for not being perfect.

- Letting go of perfectionism doesn't mean becoming sloppy. It's about setting realistic standards that you can achieve while addressing other priorities (e.g. health and happiness).
- Excel in a few important things rather than try to be 100% in everything all the time.
- We must all learn continually throughout our lives, especially in new roles or situations.
 - (i) Give yourself 3-6 months to settle fully into a *new role*. If there's something you don't know, it's ok to say "I don't know, let me check and get back to you." Learn to do research, seek help or advice, ask questions and attend training/courses.
 - (ii) Even if you're *skilled or experienced* in a role, you're still not expected to know everything. It's more critical to know how to find new ideas/solutions by applying your

KEY QUOTES

"Aiming for perfection shows an imperfect mindset."

"Perfectionism is not just unrealistic, it's also costly."

"Not aiming for perfection doesn't mean you don't care, or that you're not bothered about success."

knowledge, getting more information or leveraging on your network.

- (iii) If you're *struggling with your work*, have the courage to ask for help: seek clarity or information about the tasks, ask your boss to help you prioritize your work, or request for more time, resources or training.



Shift from Self-Doubt → Confidence



It's normal to feel insecure at times. However, imposters equate insecurity with inadequacy. Their extreme self-doubt leads them to question and overanalyze everything.

- Confidence and insecurity are actually linked. You can't be truly confident about something until you've confronted your doubts and fears. Instead of hiding your self-doubt, use it as a driving force for improvement.
- When you're confident of yourself, it's easier to try new things, reach for bigger goals, manage stress and overcome challenges.
- Internalize your achievements and strengths:
 - (i) List down *every* achievement you've made in your life, without questioning how/why you achieved it. Include your qualifications, promotions, pay raises, praises from others, leadership roles, challenges you've overcome, and any other successes in your personal life (e.g. hobbies, family). Realize that you can't have achieved all these based on luck alone.
 - (ii) Pay attention to your unique combination of strengths, skills and qualities. Think of the words that others use to describe you positively (e.g. honest, reliable, friendly). Ask ≥3 friends/family members to share your list of good qualities. Consolidate these lists to identify your *top 5 strengths/skills*.
 - (iii) Try *matching* your strengths, capabilities and experience with the tasks at hand. Your intuition will improve with time.
- Embrace all of yourself, not just the "good" parts. Each time you feel upset, reflect on what's happening and release the

KEY QUOTES

"Doing well means knowing how to get the job done, but it also means knowing your own limits."

"Sometimes our imperfections are the elements that give us our strengths."

"Being comfortable with yourself and confident in your abilities is the ultimate protection against imposter syndrome."

emotional burdens. When things go well, consider what/how it happened.

- Take 5-10 minutes daily to reflect on the good things, i.e. things that went well or made you feel good. Don't be afraid to talk about what you're proud of or what's going well for you. Celebrate every accomplishment.
- Step out of your comfort zone and do something you've been avoiding, e.g. try new things, visit new places, or tackle a challenge you've been putting off. Each time you do so, you're expanding your boundaries to explore and discover your true potential.



Managing your Moods and Feelings



Learn to manage fear and anxiety, which are at the heart of the imposter syndrome:

- Let the feelings pass naturally instead of fighting them.
- Recall how you overcame a similar concern in the past and remind yourself that you can handle it. Indeed, a study found that 85% of participants' worries never happened. Of the remaining 15% that occurred, 79% of the participants were able to handle them better than expected or learned something worthwhile.
- Use relaxation techniques (e.g. yoga, deep breathing) to calm yourself.
- Think of uncertainty as simply something you've yet to learn.
- When you're preparing for something important, use visualization to imagine yourself completing the task perfectly. Visualize the process so vividly that you can see, hear and feel every step in detail. Repeat the mental rehearsals to make it easier for your mind and body to recreate what you've visualized.



Manage low moods that may fuel your fears and self-doubts.

- Other people are too focused on their own lives to scrutinize everything you say or do. Stop worrying about what others

KEY QUOTES

"Self-awareness allows you to be aware of insecurity, rather than being insecure."

"Feelings are a bit like clouds; they're not permanent but around for a while before moving on."

"Uncertainty isn't something bad, just something you don't know the answer to yet."

think or trying to please them. Instead, start to speak up and share what you truly think.

- Avoid the comparison trap. We tend to compare the best of we see in others with the worst of what we see in ourselves. Remember: what you see on social media is also not truly representative of others' lives. Only connect with people who inspire and uplift you.
- Make time for other priorities. Periodically disconnect from your digital devices. Practice mindfulness by applying all 5 senses to your situation—what do you see, hear, touch, smell and taste? Once you notice yourself being dragged down by your worries, break the cycle by switching your focus to something else, then revisit the issue with a more constructive frame of mind.



Stop dismissing your achievements. Acknowledge the role of external factors (e.g. luck, team effort, contacts) without discounting the role of internal factors (e.g. skills, focus, perseverance, passion) or your own contributions.

- "I was just lucky." Luck plays a role in every success, but you must also put yourself in a position to attract opportunities and take the right actions to bring them to fruition.
- "It was just fluke." You must have had several successes in life, and they can't all be flukes or one-time/accidental occurrences.
- "I just worked hard." Hard work is a key ingredient for success, but it must be accompanied by curiosity, a willingness to learn, and the ability to bounce back from set backs. In any case, hard work isn't easy since it requires persistence/focus, so give yourself some credit for your effort.
- "I was in the right place at the right time." Timing is important for success, but you also need the skills to recognize the right timing and seize the advantage.
- "People just liked me." You may have a promotion, a bigger role, or an award because you're likeable, but you must also have demonstrated the necessary skills and competencies for the role. In short, likeability is a valuable skill not to be dismissed.

KEY QUOTES

"It's what you turn luck into that differentiates who is successful and who is not."

"Hard work is the core component of success, not a reason to discount it!"

- "It was a team effort." It's good to give credit where it's due, but don't dismiss your own contributions, nor your ability to lead, integrate or work with a team.
- "I knew the right people." Leveraging your network/contacts to get something done doesn't make it less valuable. After all, you need skills and effort to develop a strong network and earn the trust/goodwill of your contacts before they'll help or support you.



Beat Overwork and Avoidance to Reclaim Your Life



Reassess how you allocate your time and energy. List down everything you do in a typical day, including meals, commuting, meetings, replying to emails, and tasks in your personal life. Next to each item, estimate how much time you need. Ask yourself if you can truly fit it all in. If not, what your priorities and boundaries? Focus on just couple of items that are truly important to you, then delegate or let go of the rest.



Stop overwork and avoidance.

- Recognize the signs of overwork: regularly working late nights and weekends, repeatedly going over details, or pushing back deadlines because the work isn't "good enough".
 - Realize that hard work is a requirement for succeed, not a sign of your incompetence.
 - Fast-forward to the end of your life and imagine what your biggest regrets might be. Start making time for them *now*.
 - Finish each task at 80% (instead of 100% perfection) and see if anyone notices the difference. Think of it as improving your efficiency, not reducing your quality.
- Be aware of your avoidant strategies and why you're using them.
 - If you confront a challenge, you at least have a chance of success; if you avoid it, you'd definitely fail. See feedback as a chance to learn and improve, not something to avoid.

KEY QUOTES

"Success is not the result of one lucky strike. Lots of effort means there's space for good timing and everything to fall into place."

"Your capacity is not infinite, so choose wisely."

"It is possible to have time to enjoy your life and still be ambitious."

- (ii) If a task/challenge seems too overwhelming, just focus on the first step and how it will help you move toward your goal. Work for 45 minutes, then give yourself a tiny reward or switch to a minor task (e.g. checking emails for 15min).

 **Start living each day fully.** Goals give you a direction in life, yet life is paradoxically not about chasing goals.

- Instead of doggedly pursuing your goal, slow down slightly to appreciate what you already have. People who practice gratitude tend to be happier, healthier and more fulfilled.
- Schedule time to rejuvenate yourself. Set aside (i) "empty time" to daydream, rest and recover, and (ii) time for things that you enjoy and energize you (e.g. singing your favorite songs, or taking a nature walk).
- Reflect on these questions: What does success mean to me? What do I want from my life? What is it all for? Write down your answers and figure out your personal recipe for success.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This book is structured like a self-help guide where Dr. Hibberd walks you through the process of re-evaluating your beliefs and exploring a new way to work and live. She includes numerous real-world examples to explain the imposter syndrome and bring the concepts/strategies to life. For more details please visit drjessamy.com.

About the Author

Dr. Jessamy Hibberd is a London-based chartered clinical psychologist, author and speaker. She has over 15 years in clinical practice and runs an online clinic offering 1- to-1 therapy. She contributes regularly to various media and publications, and has authored and co-authored several bestselling books. She received her Doctorate in Clinical Psychology at Royal Holloway, University of London, and completed her accreditation in CBT at Kings College's Institute of Psychology.



KEY QUOTES

"Think of life as an adventure, something to experience rather than a mountain to conquer."

"When you become obsessed by that final goal...it can blind you to the adventure of life and its real purpose: living."

"Together we've planted the seeds of change; it's now up to you to look after them, to water and nurture them, so they continue to flower year after year."